

EXPLORE YOUR SCHOOL GROUNDS



Teacher notes | Grades 5-7 | 40-60 minutes

An inquiry that turns familiar grounds into a field site. Students compare microhabitats, collect observations, test possible explanations, and return to see change. Works without a bus or special equipment.

Route & access

Walk the site first. Choose a shared route and observation stations with stable surfaces and rest options. Every student should be able to make discoveries and direct part of the inquiry.

Materials

Print student pages; bring pencils and clipboards if useful. Sketches, labels, oral notes, or photographs (where permitted) are valid records.

Learning flow

5 min: choose boundaries and an observation point. 25-35 min: teams attempt five of nine missions. 10 min: compare evidence. 5 min: pose a question for a return visit.

Care for place

Set boundaries and a meeting point. Stay on permitted paths; observe without picking, tasting, digging, feeding wildlife, or moving habitat materials.

Evidence to listen for

Ask: "What did you actually notice?" "What else could explain it?" "Would this observation be the same in another season?"

EXPLORE YOUR SCHOOL GROUNDS



Name: _____ Date: _____ Place: _____

Choose challenges in any order. Record what you saw before explaining it.

01 MICROHABITAT

Locate two small areas that might support different living things. Compare moisture, light, shelter, or human activity.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Two differences I can point to

EVIDENCE + THINKING

Which difference might matter most?

02 THE SHADE LINE

Find sun and shade near each other. Compare temperature, ground cover, and how each place feels.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Record three contrasts

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What might change later today?

03 EVIDENCE OF A VISITOR

Find a sign that a person or animal has used this place. Do not disturb it.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Describe the clue precisely

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What else could have made it?

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04 TREE IDENTITY

Choose a tree and record bark, branching, leaves or needles, and nearby clues.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Three identifying details

EVIDENCE + THINKING

How certain is your identification?

05 SOUND TRANSECT

At two reachable spots, listen for one minute each. Count human, animal, and other sounds.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

A tally from each spot

EVIDENCE + THINKING

Why might the soundscape differ?

06 PATTERN AND MEASURE

Find a repeating natural pattern. Estimate or measure spacing, size, or frequency.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Draw and label the pattern

EVIDENCE + THINKING

Does the pattern hold everywhere?

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Choose challenges in any order. Record what you saw before explaining it.

07 WATER STORY

Look for evidence of where rainwater travels or collects. Stay away from unsafe edges.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Map the likely path

EVIDENCE + THINKING

How might heavy rain change it?

08 HUMAN CHOICES

Find one way people have changed this place, intentionally or otherwise.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Record the change

EVIDENCE + THINKING

Who or what benefits? Who may not?

09 UNANSWERED MYSTERY

Choose an observation your team cannot yet explain. Suggest a safe way to investigate.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

What we saw

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What evidence would help next?

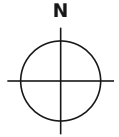
EXPLORE YOUR SCHOOL GROUNDS

Map the place, then share one discovery with a partner



Draw a map of your route or observation area. Add a key and mark your strongest evidence.

FIELD MAP / CLOSE-UP



Key: _____

My claim about this place:

Evidence that supports it:

A different explanation or a new question:

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Return to the same observation point

First visit: _____ Return visit: _____ Weather: _____

BEFORE / SKETCH + NOTES

NOW / SKETCH + NOTES

What changed? Use at least two specific observations.

What stayed similar? What might explain both the change and the pattern?

How could our class care for this place without disturbing it?
